Lesson notes · for you

# Every post leaves a trace

Cyber security · Level 2 · Lesson 1

| Time | Materials |
| --- | --- |
| 20 min | Your phone, or a family phone with its owner's permission; A notebook and a pen |

## Learning goals

- Tell your active footprint from your passive one.
- Explain why posts are hard to take back.
- Spot details that add up, and test a post before you share it.

## Activity: The puzzle game

1. Warm-up (3 min): On paper, list five things you posted, liked, searched for or watched this week. You don't need to show anyone.
2. Sort (5 min): Next to each one, write A for active (shared on purpose) or P for passive (left without noticing). Which list is longer, and which surprised you?
3. Puzzle (7 min): Alone or with a partner, read six made-up posts (from the Digital footprint lab, or ones you write yourself). Circle every place, time, birthday and pet's name, then write down what a stranger now knows.
4. Fix (5 min): Rewrite two of the posts so they keep the fun but lose the risky detail. Swap with a partner and check each other's with the three-people test.

**You only need paper and a pen. Write six short made-up posts, or use the ones in the Digital footprint lab. Never use real people's posts.**

## Discussion

- Which of your posts would a stranger find most useful?
- Why doesn't deleting a post make it disappear?
- What would you like a future school to find about you?

## Check yourself

- One detail I'll stop sharing publicly + why.

**Try it this week**
Look at your profile the way a stranger would. Count the posts that show your school, your street or your routine, and hide or delete one of them.

Worksheet

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Name _____ Class _____ Date _____

**1** **You delete an embarrassing post one hour after posting it. Is it gone for good?**

- ◯ Yes, if you delete the comments too
- ◯ Not for sure: someone may have a copy
- ◯ Yes: deleted means gone

**2** **Which of these are part of your passive footprint, the traces you leave without noticing?**

- ☐ The videos you watched to the end
- ☐ What you typed in a search box
- ☐ A photo of your birthday cake that you posted
- ☐ A comment you wrote under a friend's post
- ☐ The places your phone has been

**3** **If your account is private, strangers can never see anything you post.**

- ◯ True
- ◯ False

**4** **Match each post to what it gives away.**

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| "Same bus stop every morning at 7" | • • • • | A common security answer |
| "Whole family away for a week!" | • • • • | Your routine |
| "My cat Mishmish is the best!" | • • • • | Your school |
| A selfie in your school uniform | • • • • | When your home is empty |

✎ **Think of something you posted, or almost posted. How does it do on the three-people test: your grandmother, your head teacher and a stranger?**

Check your answers

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**1** **Not for sure: someone may have a copy**

In an hour, someone may have taken a screenshot, downloaded it or forwarded it.

**2** **The places your phone has been; The videos you watched to the end; What you typed in a search box**

Location, watch time and searches are collected without you posting anything: that's your passive footprint.

**3** **False**

A private account helps a lot, but any follower can screenshot or forward your post, and followers aren't always who they seem.

**4** **"Same bus stop every morning at 7" — Your routine**
**"Whole family away for a week!" — When your home is empty**
**"My cat Mishmish is the best!" — A common security answer**
**A selfie in your school uniform — Your school**

The same place at the same time every day is a routine, "away for a week" tells a thief when your home is empty, a pet's name is a common answer to security questions, and a uniform shows your school.